



Photographs by JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

MATTRESSES and other discarded items pile up outside an apartment complex where residents are living in Altadena. Tenants have reported smoke damage and power and gas outages. Some are using portable stoves.

Altadena families out of the fire and into a frying pan of misery

Their homes survived inferno, but residents say living at damaged complex is difficult.

By RUBEN VIVES AND ANDREA CASTILLO

In the living room of her two-bedroom apartment in Altadena, Rosa Ramirez sat alone on her couch, staring up at the smoke-stained ceiling.

In the corner of the room, boxes and bags stuffed with clothes, towels and blankets that hadn't been fouled by



ROSA RAMIREZ and her 17-year-old daughter show their fire-damaged apartment this week in Altadena.

smoke from the Eaton fire sat next to a fish tank with discolored water.

"I'm slowly going through things to see what needs to be thrown out," she said. "The kids' mattresses had to be replaced, and some of the furniture will eventually have to go, but not yet."

Until a week ago, Ramirez and her family had been staying in hotels, bouncing from city to city after January's inferno forced them to evacuate. But the money dried up, and the high cost of renting elsewhere led them to return with other tenants to the burn zone and an

[See Altadena, A5]

L.A. approves first permits for rebuilding in Palisades

Streamlined process clears 3 homeowners within 2½ months of the start of the fire.

By LIAM DILLON AND DAKOTA SMITH

The city of Los Angeles has cleared the way for three Pacific Palisades homeowners to begin rebuilding on their properties.

The approval of the projects, one to repair a damaged home and two for full rebuilds, according to the Department of Building and Safety, represents a key milestone in the recovery from January's devastating wildfires. The first permit was issued March 5, less than two months after the Palisades fire destroyed or

majorly damaged more than 6,000 homes in Pacific Palisades and surrounding areas.

"We want this to be happening on your lot, too," said Mayor Karen Bass at a news conference in the Palisades on Friday.

Bass and L.A. County leaders have pledged to streamline permitting procedures for property owners who want to rebuild. The Eaton fire, which ignited the same day, displaced 6,900 households from Altadena and nearby communities. The city and county have opened one-stop permitting

centers for fire victims and waived discretionary hearings and other zoning reviews for those who want to build new homes that are roughly the same size as they were before.

The first permit approved was for repairs to a fire-damaged primary bedroom, bathroom and garage of a split-level home near Rustic Canyon, according to city records and Paul Lobana, the structural engineer for the project. The homeowner submitted plans to city inspectors Feb. 17.

"The process worked excellently," said Lobana, who has been working on homes in Los Angeles for 40 years. "The city was very courteous."

Construction has already begun on the repairs, Lobana said.

Gary Lionelli, his wife and teenage daughter were living in a newly built home near the Palisades' main commercial strip for less than a year before the fire destroyed it. The longtime property owners decided to submit the exact blueprints as before.

"We're not going to do anything that would delay us," said Lionelli, a film composer.

With the city approval in hand, Lionelli said he hoped to commence construction once debris clearing was finished on his property. He

[See Palisades, A6]

Palos Verdes slide may take a new toll

To offset damage costs, city proposes charging motorists on a crucial coastal road.

By GRACE TOOHEY

Motorists love it for its rugged cliffs and stunning coastal vistas, but this Southern California highway is also a critical evacuation route for thousands of Palos Verdes Peninsula residents — not to mention a key artery for commuters and emergency vehicles.

Yet maintaining scenic Palos Verdes Drive South has become an increasingly costly, and practically constant, endeavor as the forces behind a relentless landslide continue to crack, shift and warp the two-lane roadway.

Now, Rancho Palos Verdes officials are contemplating a highly controversial

move to help offset the tortured thoroughfare's upkeep: turning Palos Verdes Drive South into a toll road.

Every day, an estimated 15,000 vehicles travel the road, with many motorists commuting to work or school or accessing their homes, according to the city. The roadway spans almost all of the city's coveted coastline and provides the only access to Trump National Golf Club and the Terranea Resort.

"You have to think about the impact it would have on people that have to go that way," Rancho Palos Verdes Councilmember Barbara Ferraro said at a February council meeting.

Jason Torres, a manager at the Great American International Seafood Market, just north of Palos Verdes Drive South, worries a toll would not only complicate his daily commute to work

[See Toll, A6]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

TIM QUINN, left, and Mark Golay watch testing of a desalination pod at Las Virgenes Reservoir. Their company envisions deep-sea water "farms" off Malibu.

A fresh take on tapping seawater for a thirsty state

Desalination project promises deep-ocean source with minimal environmental fallout.

By IAN JAMES

Californians could be drinking water tapped from the Pacific Ocean off Malibu several years from now — that is, if a company's new desalination technology proves viable.

OceanWell Co. plans to anchor about two dozen 40-foot-long devices, called pods, to the seafloor several miles offshore and use them to take in saltwater and pump purified fresh water to shore in a pipeline. The company calls the concept a wa-

ter "farm" and is testing a prototype of its pod at a reservoir in the foothills of the Santa Monica Mountains.

The pilot study, supported by Las Virgenes Municipal Water District, is being closely watched by managers of several large water agencies in Southern California. They hope that if the new technology proves economical, it could supply more water for cities and suburbs that are vulnerable to shortages during droughts, while avoiding the environmental drawbacks of large coastal desalination plants.

"It can potentially provide us Californians with a reliable water supply that doesn't create toxic brine that impacts marine life, nor does it have intakes that suck the life out of the

ocean," said Mark Gold, director of water scarcity solutions for the Natural Resources Defense Council. "If this technology is proven to be viable, scalable and cost-effective, it would greatly enhance our climate resilience."

During a recent demonstration at Las Virgenes Reservoir, Tim Quinn, the company's water policy strategist, watched as the 12-foot-long cylindrical prototype was lowered underwater on a cable.

"We pull fresh water only up out of the ocean, and the salt stays down there in low concentrations, where it's not an environmental problem," Quinn said.

The testing at Las Virgenes Reservoir will help the

[See Water, A8]

Overseer named to fix state prisons' mental care

By PAIGE ST. JOHN

SACRAMENTO — Following through on intentions broadcast a year ago, a federal judge is putting control of California's troubled inmate mental health programs into the hands of an outsider: President Biden's former chief of prisons.

With inmate suicide rates at an all-time high, U.S. District Senior Judge Kimberly Mueller said her aim is to force changes in California's prison mental health system, which a federal judge in 1995 deemed to be so poor as to constitute cruel and unusual punishment.

To do that, Mueller is naming a federal "receiver-nominee" to develop an oversight plan for psychiatric services for California's prison population. Three prior candidates, for varying reasons, passed up the job.

Mueller's pick to tackle the prisoner mental health care system is Colette Peters, who stepped down as Federal Bureau of Prisons director the day Donald Trump returned to the White House. The choice was announced Tuesday during a closed-door meeting with lawyers for inmates

[See Prisons, A5]

AI to ask if you want fries with that

Fast-food giant experiments with voices to help take orders at drive-throughs, call centers. **BUSINESS, A7**

Lawyers sought in cartel cases

Attorneys are wary after Mexico transfers 29 high-stakes clients to the U.S. **NATION, A4**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 73/52. **B8**

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Homelessness projections dip

Data suggest a decrease of between 5% and 10% across L.A. County. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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